WOMEN LED COOPERATIVES STRENGTHEN GUJARAT WATER SYSTEMS





Reimagining the Nal se Jal movement through local leadership

Gujarat's villages today present a quietly powerful story of progress. Away from the noise of large projects, a meaningful transformation is being shaped by the resolve of women's groups, cooperatives and local institutions. As India advances the Jal Jeevan Mission and its promise of Har Ghar Jal, Gujarat stands out not only for achieving universal tap connectivity but for nurturing a new culture of community centred water governance. The State has moved beyond installing taps to building a system anchored in trust, skill and shared responsibility.

From Infrastructure to Sustainable Service

The Nal se Jal programme under the Jal Jeevan Mission set out to bring tap water to every rural home by 2024. Gujarat entered with a strong advantage, already providing 65.16 lakh connections and covering 71.46 per cent of households in 2019, and went on to achieve full coverage by 2022.

With every home connected, attention shifted to reliable service. Gram Panchayats now oversee daily operations, repairs and financial management, ensuring that fee collection and careful use of funds keep village systems functioning smoothly.

Women's Groups and Cooperatives Take Charge

To reinforce rural water systems, the Government of India encouraged States to involve Primary Agriculture Credit Societies and Self Help Groups. Gujarat, through WASMO, signed memorandums of understanding with 81 Primary Agriculture Credit Societies and 82 Self Help Groups. These institutions manage tax collection, daily supply, minor repairs and routine maintenance.

WASMO strengthened the model through extensive capacity building, conducting 141 training batches for 5,255 members of Primary Agriculture Credit Societies and 207 batches for 10,386 members of Self Help Groups. Training covered water testing, systematic tax collection and essential technical skills.

A performance based incentive scheme announced on 19 April 2025 offers annual incentives between ₹30,000 and ₹50,000 for institutions engaged in operation and maintenance. WASMO also issued a Standard Operating Procedure covering governance, financial processes and repair protocols. Gram panchayats selected one of three models according to capacity: the no cost model, the incentive and reimbursement model or the comprehensive operation and maintenance model.

A Stronger and More Accountable Water System

This shift from construction to service delivery has strengthened Gujarat's rural water network. Community institutions collected more than ₹103 lakh in water tax in 2024 to 2025, with 22 achieving above 80 per cent recovery.

Through 348 training batches involving more than 15,600 members, Gujarat has created a technically confident grassroots workforce. Villages with active participation now report smoother tax collection, quicker repairs and more reliable daily supply. The incentive scheme has also encouraged a steady rise in new agreements, reflecting growing faith in community management.

A Model for the Future

Gujarat's experience offers a clear lesson. When communities, especially women led collectives, are trusted with real responsibility, they deliver not only efficient services but lasting ownership. This quiet transformation shows the strength of placing people at the centre of development.

WASMO CAPACITY BUILDING

- 141 batches trained 5,255 PACS members (Primary Agriculture Credit Societies)
- 207 batches trained 10,386 SHG members (Self Help Groups)
- Focus on water testing, finance and technical skills

INCENTIVE SCHEME SNAPSHOT

- Annual incentives of ₹30,000 to ₹50,000
- For institutions managing operation and maintenance
- Scheme active for two years
- Guided by a detailed Standard Operating Procedure

IMPACT AT A GLANCE

- ₹103 lakh collected in water tax in FY 2024 to 2025
- 22 institutions crossed 80 per cent recovery
- 348 batches trained more than 15,600 members
- Villages report better tax collection, timely repairs and more reliable supply